C2 Listening

Spoken discourse markers

Follow a fast, natural speaker through markers like mind you, that said, anyway and as I say.

Natural speech is full of small markers that steer the listener: they add a reservation, return to a point, change topic or soften a claim. Missing them means missing how the speaker's view shifts.

Marker	Function	Example
mind you / that said	Adds a reservation	*It's expensive. Mind you, it lasts for years.*
anyway	Closes a side point or returns to the main one	*Anyway, as I was saying…*
as I say	Repeats an earlier point for emphasis	*As I say, timing is everything.*
to be fair	Concedes a point to the other side	*To be fair, they did warn us.*
at the end of the day	Introduces the speaker's bottom line	*At the end of the day, it's your decision.*

Listen

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So should you buy an electric car right now? Well, the running costs are much lower, no question. Mind you, the price up front is still pretty steep. My neighbour got one last year, and he loves it, though, to be fair, he hardly ever drives long distances. Anyway, the charging network is improving fast, and that was always the big worry. That said, if you live in a flat with no parking, it's a real headache. So, as I say, it depends on how you live. At the end of the day, if you can charge at home, I'd go for it.

Mark the turns. Each *mind you*, *to be fair* and *that said* is a change of direction. Note the point that follows each one.

Common mistake. Taking every sentence as equally important. *At the end of the day* introduces the speaker's real conclusion; earlier points are steps on the way.

Practice

1. What advantage of electric cars does the speaker mention first?
2. What reservation follows *Mind you*?
3. Why does the speaker add *to be fair* about the neighbour?
4. What problem follows *That said*?
5. What is the speaker's final recommendation?

▼ **Show answers**

1. Running costs are much lower.
2. The price up front is still high.
3. To admit the neighbour's good experience may not apply to everyone, because he rarely drives long distances.
4. Living in a flat with no parking makes charging difficult.
5. Buy one if you can charge at home.